

be anywhere (living it up in Monaco, Paris, or Miami) and anyone (Beyonce, Oprah). Ah, to be young and naïve.

To give you some more insight as to where my head was, I'll add some color around my thought process during this time. It took me five years to complete my four-year college degree. I was extremely fortunate that along with a partial scholarship to support my tuition costs, my mother paid for my college education. But despite this, there were times that even with my mother's support and my partial scholarship, I had to go to school part-time because my mom didn't have enough money for my tuition and I couldn't qualify for student loans as an international student (which in retrospect was a blessing in disguise). Given the extended time it took me to get through college, by the time I got to graduation, I was ready to make some real money and make it fast.

I wanted to make my parents proud and show my mom that her investment in my college education and the opportunity she provided to me was worth it. And so, once I got my first full-time job, I wanted all my money deposited in my checking account where I could see it, not sent to a random scheme called a 401(k), with words like *fees, expenses, risk, not guaranteed*, and *assumed liability* being used in the description—a scheme that also, in my mind, had no immediate impact on my current day-to-day life. I was like, “Thanks, sounds great, but no thank you very much!”

But then, on the second day of my job's orientation, just as I was getting ready to tune out during the overview of my employer-sponsored retirement plans and their 401(k), I heard the words *free money* and I immediately perked up. I mean, *free* and *money* mentioned in the same sentence? And said by the very important lady from HR, no less? Sign me up! Those two simple words were a complete game-changer for me.

I learned my employer was offering a free contribution match of 100% up to 6% of my own contributions. I might not have known or even cared about the 401(k) at the time, but I sure knew a good deal when I saw one, and so I signed up for my company's 401(k) and made sure I contributed just enough to get the full match they were offering. It took a few months to be fully enrolled, but as soon as I saw how quickly the money was accumulating from my consistent payroll deductions each and every paycheck I got interested in contributing more than was required to get the